VCE MUN 2026

Background Guide

Agenda: *Preventing, combating and eradicating the illicit trade of Small Arms and Light Weapons (SALW) in all its aspects.*

Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

We are very pleased to welcome you to the simulation of the ***UNGA: DISEC*** at ***VCE MUN 2026***. It is an honour to serve as your Executive Board for the duration of the conference. This Background Guide is designed to give you an insight into the case at hand, so we hope this acts as only a ***catalyst*** for furthering your research and not limited to just this guide. Please refer to it carefully. Remember, a thorough understanding of the problem is the first step to solving it.

Do understand that this Background Guide is in no way exhaustive and is only meant to provide you with enough background information to establish a platform for beginning the research. Delegates are highly recommended to do a good amount of research beyond what is covered in the Guide. The guide cannot be used as proof during the committee proceedings under any circumstances.

We understand that MUN conferences can be an overwhelming experience for first-timers but it must be noted that our aspirations from the delegates are not how experienced or articulate they are. Rather, we want to see how one manages the balance to respect disparities and differences of opinion and work around this while extending their foreign policy to present comprehensive solutions without compromising on their self-interests and initiate consensus building.

New ideas are by their very nature disruptive, but far less disruptive than a world set against the backdrop of stereotypes and regional instability due to which reform is essential in policy making and conflict resolution. At any point during your research, do not hesitate to contact the Executive Board Members for clarifications or in case you need help in any other aspect. We look forward to a fruitful discussion and an enriching experience with all of you.

Best regards,

Eswar Chava	*Suraj Veerubhotla*	*Tejasvi Kaniganti*
Chairperson	**Vice Chairperson**	**Rapporteur**

Important Points to Remember

A few aspects that delegates should keep in mind while preparing:

1. **Procedure:** The purpose of putting in procedural rules in any committee is to ensure a more organized and efficient debate. The committee will follow the UNA-USA Rules of Procedure. Although the Executive Board shall be fairly strict with the Rules of Procedure, the discussion of the agenda will be the main priority. So, delegates are advised not to restrict their statements due to hesitation regarding procedure.
2. **Foreign Policy:** Following the foreign policy of one's country is the most important aspect of a Model UN Conference. This is what essentially differentiates a Model UN from other debating formats. To violate one's foreign policy without adequate reason is one of the worst mistakes a delegate can make.
3. **Role of the Executive Board:** The Executive Board is appointed to facilitate debate. The committee shall decide the direction and flow of debate. The delegates are the ones who constitute the committee and hence must be uninhibited while presenting their opinions/stance on any issue. However, the Executive Board may put forward questions and/or ask for clarifications at all points of time to further debate and test participants.
4. **Nature of Source/Evidence:** This Background Guide is meant solely for research purposes and must not be cited as evidence to substantiate statements made during the conference. Evidence or proof for substantiating statements made during formal debate is acceptable from the following sources:

    a. **United Nations:** Documents and findings by the United Nations or any related UN body is held as a credible proof to support a claim or argument. Multilateral Organizations: Documents from international organizations like OIC, NATO, SAARC, BRICS, EU, ASEAN, the International Court of Justice, etc. may also be presented as credible sources of information.

    b. **Government Reports:** These reports can be used in a similar way as the State Operated News Agencies reports and can, in all circumstances, be denied by another country.

    c. **News Sources:**

        1. Reuters: Any Reuters article that clearly makes mention of the fact or is in contradiction of the fact being stated by a delegate in council.

        2. State operated News Agencies: These reports can be used in the support of or against the State that owns the News Agency. These reports, if credible or substantial enough, can be used in support of or against any country as such but in that situation, may be denied by any other country in the council. Some examples are – RIA Novosti (Russian Federation), Xinhua News Agency (People's Republic of China), etc.

****Please Note: Reports from NGOs working with UNESCO, UNICEF and other UN bodies will be accepted.* ***Under no circumstances will sources like Wikipedia, or newspapers like the Guardian, Times of India, etc. be accepted.*** *However, notwithstanding the criteria for acceptance of sources and evidence, delegates are still free to quote/cite from any source as they deem fit as a part of their statements.*

Guidelines

- Read the entirety of the background guide in the order it was written. Make sure to highlight the names of specific treaties, documents, resolutions, conventions, international bodies, events and any other specific incidents so that you can get back to them later and do a lot more thorough research.

- Understand some of the basic details regarding the country that you've been allotted whether this be the capital, current affairs regarding geopolitical situation, political hierarchy etc. While not strictly necessary, you never know when this can turn out to be handy. Geography Now's A - Z Country List has been a particularly helpful resource for this.

- Use a search engine of your choice to create as many tabs as possible for the highlighted terms from your background guide. Wikipedia or a YouTube video act as a great way to get a brief summary of the incidents at hand but such sources (especially Wikipedia articles) cannot be used in committee as sources.

- Delve into deeper research regarding the particular position of your allocation with the agenda at hand. Try searching for the voting stances of your allocation in related conventions and understanding the reasons for voting as so. UN Press Releases are also a helpful source for this matter.

- Find the website for the foreign ministry of the country you have been assigned alongside the "Permanent Mission of COUNTRY to the United Nations" website and search for a key term relating to the agenda, this should often give you statements from recent press conferences or UN committee sessions that can act as valuable sources of information in forming a position.

- Keep a handy copy of the Charter of the United Nations, whether as a .pdf file extension or a physical copy works. This contains the founding principles of the United Nations and contains articles that lay out the mandate of the six bodies that the United Nations is primarily divided into. Spend some additional time researching the specific mandate and functions of the committee that you have been assigned.

- The Executive Board may ask for the source of a statement that a delegate makes in committee either during a Point of Order circumstance or if said statement stands to be of interest to the Executive Board. Therefore, it is recommended that delegates keep track of their sources when making / disputing a claim and also ensure their validity. Please do remember that while you as a delegate are allowed to cite any source you wish during committee.

Hierarchy of evidence

Evidence can be presented from a wide variety of sources, but not all sources are treated as equal. Here's the hierarchy in which evidence is categorised:

Tier 1: Includes any publication, statement, resolution, or document released by any of the Nations' official organs or committees; any publication, statement, or document released by a UN member state in its own capacity. The evidence falling in this tier is considered most reliable during the simulation.

Tier 2: Includes: any news article published by any official media source that is owned and controlled by a UN member state. E.g.: Xinhua News (China), Prasar Bharti (India), BBC (United Kingdom) etcetera. The evidence falling in this tier is considered sufficiently reliable in case no other evidence from any Tier 1 source is available on that particular fact, event, or situation.

Tier 3: Includes: any publication from news sources of international repute such as Reuters, The New York Times, Agence-France Presse, etcetera. The evidence falling under this tier is considered the least reliable for the purposes of this simulation. Yet, if no better source is available in a certain scenario, it may be considered.

Foreign Policy and Foreign Relations

Foreign policy, in simple terms, is what your country aims to achieve in regard to the issue at hand or in general with its relations with other countries.

1. What role must foreign policy play in your research?

Understanding the foreign policy of your country must be a checkbox that you tick off at the very beginning of your research.

Your foreign policy should dictate everything from the arguments you make, the reasoning you give for making those arguments, and the actions you take in the Council.

2. Where do I look to find foreign policy?

Most of the time, foreign policy is not explicitly stated. It must be inferred from the actions and statements issued by the country. Reading the meeting records from previous meetings of UNSC (or any other UN body where your country might have spoken on the issue) is a great place to start. If such records are unavailable, look for statements from your country's Foreign Ministry (or equivalent like Ministry of External Affairs, Ministry for Foreign Affairs etcetera) and top leadership (PM, Pres., Secretary of State, Defence Minister).

Foreign Relations on the other hand refers to the diplomatic ties that one country has with another and considers elements such as the mutual presence of embassies, consulates, ambassadors & diplomatic dialogue. More often than not, foreign policy is what will be of your primary concern during the MUN, but it is important to also consider any extremities in your allotted country's foreign relations.

Preface

Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), formally recognized as the First Committee of the General Assembly, holds a primary mandate established by the Charter of the United Nations to address issues of international peace, security, and disarmament. In the context of the illicit trade in small arms and light weapons (SALW), DISEC functions as the principal deliberative body where all 193 Member States negotiate the normative frameworks and political commitments that govern conventional arms control. The committee's mandate is predicated on the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, as outlined in Article 11 of the UN Charter.

The operational scope of DISEC regarding SALW is distinct from the enforcement powers of the Security Council. While the Security Council addresses specific conflict situations and imposes legally binding arms embargoes under Chapter VII, DISEC focuses on the "universal" aspect of disarmament, establishing standards for marking, record-keeping, and the identification of diverted weapons. The committee's mandate has evolved since its inception in 1945, shifting from a preoccupation with nuclear non-proliferation to an increasingly sophisticated focus on conventional weapons, which are responsible for the vast majority of conflict-related deaths in the 21st century.

The resolutions are informed by the reports of the Secretary-General and facilitate the implementation of the United Nations Programme of Action (PoA) and the International Tracing Instrument (ITI). To coordinate these multi-faceted efforts, the UN employs the Coordinating Action on Small Arms (CASA) mechanism, which comprises 21 UN departments and agencies working collaboratively on different aspects of small arms control, ranging from public health to border management.

The relationship between DISEC and the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) is symbiotic; UNODA provides the technical support and expertise required for

DISEC to fulfil its mandate, particularly in facilitating dialogue and confidence-building measures among states. Despite its inability to mandate action, this committee remains one of the main multilateral forums where global consensus can be reached on the definitions and standards of the arms trade, thereby shaping the legitimacy of state behaviour on the international stage.

Introduction to the Committee

The United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) is one of the six organs of the United Nations (UN) and the primary policy making and representative organ of the United Nations where all of the 193 members of the UN are represented in the General Assembly. The Disarmament and International Security Committee is the first committee under the General Assembly that deals with disarmament, global challenges and threats to world peace.

The six committees of the United Nations General Assembly being:

- First Committee - Disarmament & International Security,
- Second Committee - Economic & Financial Council,
- Third Committee - Social, Humanitarian & Cultural Issues,
- Fourth Committee - Special Political & Decolonization Committee,
- Fifth Committee - Administrative & Budgetary, &
- Sixth Committee - Legal.

Mandate

The Disarmament and International Security Committee is mandated to address the nuclear, chemical, biological, conventional, etc. weapon proliferation and to deal with the issues threatening international security and peace.

DISEC makes recommendations to the UNGA regarding the resolutions and establishes principles and international cooperation between states to maintain global security. It considers all disarmament and international security matters within the scope of the Charter or relating to the powers and functions of any other organ of the United Nations; the general principles of cooperation in the maintenance of international peace and security, as well as principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments; promotion of cooperative arrangements and measures aimed at strengthening stability through lower levels of armaments.

DISEC works closely with other UN bodies and agencies like the United Nations Office on Disarmament Affairs (UNODA) and International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA). The First Committee sessions are structured into three distinctive stages:

1. General debate,
2. Thematic discussions, &
3. Action on Drafts.

Background

The discourse on the illicit trade of small arms and light weapons enters a transformative phase in 2026. This year is defined not merely by the persistence of conflict but by a fundamental shift in how weapons are manufactured, traded, and utilized by both state and non-state actors. Recent conflict-data analyses indicate a significant increase in annual violent-event fatalities, with hundreds of thousands of deaths recorded, and UN debates have noted that nearly half of all violent deaths in recent years involve SALW.

The year 2026 holds particular significance due to the operationalization of the Open-ended Technical Expert Group (TEG) on SALW, a body established by the Fourth Review Conference (RevCon4) in June 2024. The TEG is tasked with addressing the challenges posed by new technologies such as 3D printing and modular designs to the International Tracing Instrument (ITI). These meetings in 2026 represent the first formal effort to integrate 21st-century manufacturing techniques into 20th-century regulatory frameworks, a gap that has increasingly allowed illicit traffickers to operate with impunity.

Furthermore, the geopolitical environment of 2026 is characterized by a "renewed military competition" among major global powers. The return of "might is right" politics and the subsequent erosion of multilateral trade and security norms have created a permissive environment for arms proliferation. As major powers modernize their own arsenals, the resulting surplus of conventional weapons is frequently diverted to non-state armed groups (VNSAs), fuelling "forever wars" across the Global South. The urgency of action in 2026 is further compounded by the rapidly approaching 2030 deadline for the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), particularly Target 16.1, which aims to reduce all forms of violence and related death rates.

The importance of the 2026 discussions also lies in the realization that the traditional "supply-side" security responses, such as mere stockpile management, are insufficient. There is an emerging consensus on the need for holistic, prevention-oriented approaches that address the root causes of demand including economic fragility, climate change, and the lack of accountable governance. As the world enters 2026, the illicit trade in SALW is no longer viewed solely as a law enforcement problem but as a fundamental governance and development challenge.

What are Small Arms and Light Weapons?

The technical definition of small arms and light weapons (SALW) is essential for effective regulation, marking, and tracing. According to the UN's International Tracing Instrument (ITI), SALW are defined as any man-portable lethal weapon that expels or launches, is designed to expel or launch, or may be readily converted to expel or launch a shot, bullet or projectile by

the action of an explosive. This definition technically excludes antique small arms and light weapons or their replicas, which are defined according to domestic law.

Categorization of Small Arms

Small arms are weapons designed for individual service and use, meaning they can be carried and operated by a single person. They generally operate within a specified calibre spectrum.

- **Handguns:** These include revolvers and self-loading pistols. They are characterized by their small size and ease of concealment, which makes them the weapon type most frequently used in urban crime.
- **Shoulder Arms:** Rifles and carbines, including fully automatic assault rifles (e.g., AK-47, M16) and sub-machine guns. These weapons are often identified by their larger curvature magazines and are the cause of the highest number of arms-related deaths globally.
- **Light Machine Guns:** Portable firearms that fire in bursts and are capable of a high rate of sustained fire. They are often belt-fed and can be fired by one person.

Categorization of Light Weapons

Light weapons are more powerful than small arms and are generally designed for use by a crew of two or three persons serving as a team, although some modern configurations allow for use by a single person.

- **Heavy Machine Guns:** Crew-served kinetic firearms providing sustained long-range fire.
- **Portable Launchers:** Rocket-Propelled Grenades (RPGs), Man-Portable Air Defence Systems (MANPADS), and man-portable launchers of anti-tank missile and rocket systems.
- **Mortars:** Specifically systems with a calibre of less than 100 mm.
- **Explosive Devices:** Certain man-portable explosive munitions, such as hand grenades, are often addressed in SALW control programmes, though landmines fall under separate legal instruments.

The inclusion of ammunition is a critical evolution in the UN framework. In 2023, the UN General Assembly adopted the Global Framework for Through-life Conventional Ammunition Management (GFA), which provides a life-cycle-based approach to managing everything from small-calibre rounds to large conventional ammunition, acknowledging that firearms are useless without their corresponding projectiles.

Root Causes of Illicit Trade and the Process of Diversion

The illicit trade in SALW is not an isolated phenomenon but the result of systemic failures at multiple stages of a weapon's lifecycle. UNODC research indicates that approximately 88-90%

of seized firearms were originally manufactured legally and subsequently diverted to the black market. Understanding this "process of diversion" where weapons leave the legal domain to enter unauthorized use is fundamental to preventing illicit flows.

Diversion from Legal Stockpiles

The primary source of illicit arms remains the leakage, theft, or captures from state-controlled stocks. This occurs when governments fail to maintain secure storage or when institutional weaknesses compromise the integrity of security forces.

- **Theft and Corruption:** Firearms are often diverted through organized attacks on government armouries or through "corrupt sale and unauthorized lease" of issued weapons by soldiers and police officers. In fragile states, underpaid security personnel may view service weapons as tradeable commodities.
- **Leakage and Abandonment:** Weapons seized by judicial authorities can "leak" back into the market if storage is insecure, while others may be abandoned by state forces during tactical retreats.
- **Battlefield Recovery:** During intense conflict, weapons are captured from retreating or surrendered forces. In Sudan, the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) have leveraged captured gear to build sophisticated decentralized supply chains that counter the air superiority of the Sudanese Armed Forces.
- **State Collapse:** The total breakdown of government authority results in mass dispersal of weapons. The collapse of the Gaddafi regime in Libya turned the country into a major hub, with diverted SALW circulating as far as Somalia and across the Sahel.

Black Markets and Cross-Border Trafficking

Once weapons exit the legal domain, they enter a complex network of regional black markets facilitated by "porous borders" and long-standing informal trade routes.

- **Overlapping Economies:** In the Sahel and Great Lakes, arms trafficking is enmeshed with the smuggling of gold, livestock, and cigarettes. These networks often overlap with legitimate economic systems, making them difficult for law enforcement to distinguish from formal trade.
- **The Crime-Terror Nexus:** Terrorist groups use historic trade routes to move weapons, often as a form of "currency" to secure informal loans. These groups generate indirect income by taxing smuggling routes or providing "protection services" for other traffickers.

Craft Production and Ghost Guns

A rapidly emerging threat is the rise of "Privately Made Firearms" (PMFs) produced outside industrial supply chains, which represent a growing fraction of seized arms.

- **Conversion and Reactivation:** Unregulated workshops convert "blank-firing" or "gas-firing" pistols into live-firing firearms. In Western Europe and Latin America, the reactivation of decommissioned military weapons is a major source of supply.
- **Additive Manufacturing:** 3D printing technology allows for the production of "ghost guns" without serial numbers. Advanced hybrid models like the "FGC-9" and "Urutau" use 3D-printed frames combined with legal metal components (like steel tubes), making them nearly indistinguishable from commercial guns in performance but invisible to traditional regulation.
- **Modular Challenges:** The shift toward modular weapon designs and the use of polymers in manufacturing present severe challenges for the International Tracing Instrument (ITI), as identifying marks can be easily removed or swapped.

Online and Dark Web Sales

The digital revolution has transformed arms brokering into an anonymous, borderless threat.

- **Digital Hubs:** The Dark Web serves as a marketplace where criminal syndicates and terrorist networks coordinate purchases using anonymous identities and generative AI to create fake credentials.
- **Financial Flow Challenges:** Transactions are increasingly conducted via cryptocurrencies and informal remittance systems, making it difficult to track funding. This digital-physical nexus facilitates "straw purchases," where individuals buy firearms lawfully to later aggregate them into significant illicit streams.
- **Legal Response:** In 2025, the UN Convention against Cybercrime opened for signature, aiming to standardize the collection of "electronic evidence" to improve the prosecution of technology-enabled arms trafficking.

Security Threats Due to SALW

The proliferation of SALW is a fundamental catalyst for violence, acting as a "multiplier of the crisis" in various contexts. Beyond immediate fatalities, these weapons enable the systemic violation of international humanitarian law (IHL) and facilitate a wide array of secondary security threats.

Escalating Civilian Casualties and Civil Wars

Small arms and light weapons are the "weapons of choice" in contemporary civil wars due to their durability and low cost. In 2024, the UN recorded around 48,000 conflict-related civilian deaths, with small arms responsible for up to 30% in many contexts. In sub-Saharan Africa, SALW accounted for approximately 30% of all recorded deaths in 2023-2024.

- **Urban Siege and Paralysis:** In Haiti, gang control of urban areas using sophisticated weaponry has paralyzed social and economic life.

- **Evolving Conflict Zones:** The persistence of conflicts in Gaza, Myanmar, Sudan, and Ukraine into 2025-2026 highlights the role of illicit flows in sustaining protracted violence despite international pressure.

Terrorism and "Accelerant Markets"

Terrorist organizations, such as ISIS affiliates in the Sahel and al-Shabaab in Somalia, rely on SALW not just for attacks but to sustain their political and economic operations.

- **Indirect Financing:** SALW enables organizations to control "accelerant markets" illicit economies like kidnapping for ransom, cattle rustling, and fuel theft. In West Africa, cattle rustling generates losses estimated at $432 million USD annually in Nigeria alone, directly financing groups like JNIM.
- **Extortion and Governance:** Armed groups use SALW to tax smuggling routes and extort artisanal gold mines, creating parallel systems of "criminal governance" that undermine state authority.

Proliferation of Improvised and Technology-Driven Weapons

A major security trend for 2026 is the convergence of small arms with emerging technologies.

- **FPV Drones and Loitering Munitions:** Cheap First-Person-View (FPV) drones (approx. $1,000 USD) are increasingly being used to deliver explosive payloads with precision, a tactic that has shifted the balance of asymmetric warfare in Ukraine, Myanmar, and the Middle East.
- **AI-Assisted Targeting:** The integration of AI into conventional weapons raises urgent ethical and legal questions regarding the threshold for armed conflict and the responsibility for civilian harm.
- **Improvised Weapons:** Built from dual-use components, these weapons frequently bypass existing international controls, exposing significant regulatory gaps.

Impact on Vulnerable Populations and Human Rights

The human cost of SALW proliferation is deeply gendered and age-specific.

- **Grave Violations Against Children:** In 2024, the UN verified 41,370 grave violations against children in armed conflict, a 25% increase from the previous year. This includes a surge in the recruitment and use of children as human shields and in combat roles.
- **Conflict-Related Sexual Violence (CRSV):** New research indicates that an average of 70-90% of documented incidents of CRSV between 2022 and 2024 involved firearms.
- **Weaponization of Civil Society:** In regions where state security is absent, such as Iraq and Lebanon, civilians are increasingly driven to the illicit market for self-protection, purchasing "house guns" which in turn increases the risk of domestic violence and accidental discharge.

Existing International Actions and Frameworks

The global response to SALW is anchored in a multi-layered structure of political commitments, criminal justice protocols, and technical guidelines coordinated by the UN system.

UN Programme of Action (UNPoA)

Adopted in 2001, the United Nations Programme of Action (UNPoA) is the cornerstone of global efforts to address illicit small arms and light weapons. In June 2024, the Fourth Review Conference (RevCon4) resulted in a landmark outcome document that reinforced commitments to strengthen national regulations, improve international cooperation, and integrate gender considerations into SALW control measures.

- **Sixth-Year Measure Cycle:** RevCon4 established action-oriented measures for the 2024–2030 period, emphasizing the need for comprehensive approaches that address the entire weapon life cycle.
- **BMS9 and OETEG:** The UN General Assembly, via resolution 79/40, decided to convene the Ninth Biennial Meeting of States (BMS9) from 1 to 5 June 2026. This meeting will host the newly established Open-Ended Technical Expert Group (OETEG) to develop recommendations on overcoming challenges posed by polymers, modular weapons, and 3D printing.

International Tracing Instrument (ITI) and OETEG

The International Tracing Instrument (ITI), adopted in 2005, fulfils the UNPoA's commitment to enable states to identify and trace illicit weapons in a timely and reliable manner.

- **Marking Obligations:** States commit to requiring unique markings at the time of manufacture, import, and transfer from government stocks to civilian use. All markings must be on an exposed surface, readable, and durable.
- **Record-Keeping:** The ITI mandates that records for the purpose of tracing be kept for at least 20 years for exports and imports, while records of manufacture must be kept indefinitely by the state.
- **Technological Modernization:** The 2026 OETEG is specifically mandated to address how the ITI can adapt to 21st-century manufacturing, ensuring that "ghost guns" do not remain invisible to global tracing efforts.

Arms Trade Treaty (ATT)

The Arms Trade Treaty (ATT), which entered into force in 2014, is the first legally binding global instrument to regulate the international trade in conventional weapons.

- **Risk Assessments:** Article 7 requires exporting states to conduct objective assessments for "overriding risk" that transferred arms could be used for serious IHL/IHRL violations, terrorism, or gender-based violence.

- **Universalization Champions:** Current efforts, as discussed in the Tenth and Eleventh Conferences of States Parties (CSP10/CSP11), focus on "Treaty Universalization" to close persistent gaps in global arms flow data.

UNODC Firearms Protocol (The Criminal Justice Pillar)

The Protocol against the Illicit Manufacturing of and Trafficking in Firearms is the only legally binding global instrument that addresses the "criminal side" of the issue.

- **Criminalization:** States parties are required to establish as criminal offenses the illicit manufacturing and trafficking of firearms, including the unauthorized assembly of weapons from trafficked parts.
- **Transnational Cooperation:** It mandates mutual legal assistance and information exchange among law enforcement to track the funding and logistics of criminal syndicates.

Global Framework for Through-life Conventional Ammunition Management (2023)

Adopted in December 2023 by resolution 78/47, this new international instrument fills a major gap by providing political commitments specifically for ammunition.

- **15 Objectives:** The framework lists 15 objectives and 85 measures aimed at reducing safety risks (unplanned explosions) and security risks (diversion to terrorists).
- **Life-Cycle Approach:** It promotes safe management from production and acquisition through storage and eventual disposal.

Technical and Operational Support Tools

- **MOSAIC:** The Modular Small-arms-control Implementation Compendium (MOSAIC) provides over 20 voluntary, practical guidance notes for practitioners on everything from "Designing a National Action Plan" to "Gendered nature of SALW".
- **SALIENT:** The Saving Lives Entity (SALIENT) is a joint UNODA-UNDP funding facility that provides sustained financing for catalytic activities that mainstream arms control into development and security efforts. Phase 2.0 was launched in 2025 to expand pilot projects in countries like South Sudan and Jamaica.
- **CASA:** The Coordinating Action on Small Arms (CASA) mechanism ensures that 21 UN entities avoid siloing their efforts, linking arms control to humanitarian aid, public health, and urban development.

Challenges to Implementation

The implementation of SALW control instruments faces significant political, technical, and legal hurdles that limit their effectiveness in 2026.

Failure and Credibility of the ATT

A major challenge is the perceived gap between State commitments and their actual arms transfer practices.

- **Low Reporting Compliance:** Only approximately 60% of States Parties submit timely and complete reports. As of August 2025, 42% of required States have either never submitted an annual report or have at least one outstanding report, creating persistent gaps in global arms flow data.
- **Subjectivity in Risk Assessments:** Article 7 (export risk assessments) relies on the diligence of individual States to determine "overriding risk." Critics argue that political and economic considerations often "trump" humanitarian imperatives, leading to continued transfers to conflict zones.
- **Transparency Deficit:** Discussions within ATT forums have remained largely theoretical, avoiding substantive debate on how States apply Treaty provisions to actual transfer decisions in active conflicts.

Sovereignty vs. Inspections

The tension between international oversight and national sovereignty remains a fundamental barrier to verification.

- **Sovereign Immunity:** States frequently invoke "Sovereign Immunity" to evade liability for operational negligence or to shield their military acquisitions from international monitoring.
- **Resistance to Monitoring:** Many States view the inspection of national stockpiles as an infringement on their internal affairs. This shift toward a "state-centric approach" has led some major powers to reject binding treaties in favor of voluntary guidelines, eroding the universality of global security norms.

Effectiveness of Sanctions and Arms Embargoes

UN arms embargoes often suffer from poor enforcement and "embargo-busting" practices.

- **Enforcement Gaps:** Meta-regression analysis suggests that embargoes have only a "weak, yet statistically significant" impact unless they are comprehensive and imposed by multiple senders.
- **Case Specifics:** In Libya, the embargo remains ineffective as armed groups obtain weapons through supply chains controlled or ignored by other Member States. In Sudan, foreign weapons continue to flow into the Darfur region in blatant violation of Council mandates, fueled by external interference from powerful backers.

Technical Hurdles to Tracing

Technological advancements are outpacing the regulatory capacity of existing instruments like the International Tracing Instrument (ITI).

- **Polymers and Modular Design:** The use of polymer frames and modular components makes it difficult to maintain durable markings and reliable records, as parts can be easily swapped or serial numbers removed.
- **Craft and 3D Production:** The proliferation of digital blueprints for "ghost guns" allows for production outside of conventional industrial oversight, making traditional factory-based regulation increasingly irrelevant.

Case Study: Africa

Africa remains the continent most acutely impacted by the proliferation of SALW, where weapons act as a "cancer" driving instability across several key sub-regions.

The Sahel (Mali, Niger, Burkina Faso)

The Sahel region has become an epicentre of armed violence fuelled by a nexus between violent extremism and the illicit gold trade.

- **Resource Nexus:** Terrorist groups like JNIM generate significant revenue by extorting artisanal gold mining communities and taxing smuggling routes.
- **Impact on Stability:** In Burkina Faso, armed attacks using SALW have killed thousands and displaced over half a million civilians since 2015, compounding developmental challenges and driving the radicalization of youth.
- **Trafficking Shifts:** Since mid-2023, traditional smuggling routes into northern Mali have been disrupted by military offensives, forcing traffickers to seek alternative sources and increasingly rely on small drones.

The Horn of Africa (Sudan and South Sudan)

The Horn is defined by protracted civil wars where SALW are the primary tools of mass atrocities.

- **Sudan's Attrition War:** As of late 2025, the conflict between the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and Rapid Support Forces (RSF) has entered a "dangerous phase" of intensified hostilities and systemic ethnic attacks in North Darfur. External actors continue to ship weapons into Darfur in blatant violation of UN arms embargoes.
- **South Sudan Benchmarks:** While some elements of the South Sudan arms embargo were softened in 2022 to support peace agreements, progress toward the Council's "key benchmarks" for lifting the embargo remains under assessment as of 2025/2026.
- **Militarized Cattle Rustling:** Traditional livestock raiding has evolved into a lethal commercial activity due to the availability of SALW, resulting in annual losses of $432 million USD in Nigeria and similar patterns in South Sudan and Ethiopia.

The Great Lakes Region (DRC)

In the Eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo, the proliferation of SALW is inextricably linked to the struggle over critical minerals.

- **VNSA Dominance:** The M23 armed group has seized large areas in North and South Kivu, displacing over 6.4 million people as of 2025.
- **Monitoring Challenges:** Despite the presence of MONUSCO and a UN Group of Experts, armed groups continue to obtain weapons through logistical supply chains that often overlap with regional resource trade.

Case Study: The Middle East

The Middle East remains the world's most pervasive arms market, with a "weaponized civil society" and constant influxes from external powers.

Syria and Iraq

Political transitions and instability in Syria have created major risks for arms proliferation.

- **Recycled Arsenals:** Conflict zones are flooded with leftover weapons from the 1980s Iran-Iraq war and Soviet-era equipment from the 1990s Yugoslav wars.
- **ISIS Resurgence:** Despite leadership losses, ISIS maintains cells along key ground lines of communication in Syria, using IEDs and light weapons to target transitional forces.
- **Civilian Armament:** In Lebanon and Iraq, where state security is perceived as inadequate, civilians have turned to "house guns" for protection. By 2021, nearly 20% of Iraq's population and 32% of Lebanon's population owned firearms, creating a vast reservoir for potential black market re-entry.

Yemen and the Red Sea

Yemen represents a critical hub for maritime arms trafficking that threatens both regional stability and global trade.

- **Houthi Supply Chains:** The Houthi movement has evolved from a low-tech insurgent group into a disruptive global force, building advanced missiles and drones using parts smuggled through a complex web of international supply chains.
- **Dhow Interdictions:** In June 2025, local authorities claimed seizing 750 tons of illicit weapons and materiel bound for Houthi forces. Traffickers frequently use small "Jelbut" dhows to transport arms and dual-use precursor chemicals like ammonium perchlorate.
- **Regional Spillover:** There are reports that Houthis are increasingly smuggling weapons through Sudan to avoid naval interdictions in the Gulf of Aden, further linking Middle Eastern and African conflict dynamics.

Emerging Trends and Technologies

The "technological evolution" of the SALW market is outpacing the capacity of existing regulatory frameworks.

AI and Small Drone Warfare

Small First-Person-View (FPV) drones are becoming increasingly important in modern combat, as seen in the war between Russia and Ukraine. These drones are cheap (~$1,000 USD), easy to fly, and can carry explosive payloads that destroy equipment worth millions. The proliferation of these "suicide drones" to non-state actors raises urgent legal and moral questions about responsibility and the "threshold for armed conflict". Artificial Intelligence is also reshaping warfare through "AI-assisted targeting," which challenges the requirement for human control over lethal force.

Additive Manufacturing (3D Printing)

The rise of 3D-printed "ghost guns" poses a severe threat to tracing efforts. These weapons lack serial numbers and can be produced in small workshops outside of conventional factory oversight. In 2024 and 2025, UNIDIR surveys indicated that 58 out of 80 responding Member States reported the presence or production of craft-produced SALW in their territories. The 2026 Technical Expert Group will be the first formal body to address whether new international instruments are needed to regulate these modular and polymer-based weapons.

Market Growth and Commercial Drivers

The global small arms market is expected to grow from $10.75 billion in 2026 to $13.41 billion by 2031. This growth is driven by increased defence procurement, the modernization of NATO and Asia-Pacific armed forces, and a surge in civilian demand for personal-protection firearms. However, supply chain disruptions and "ESG-aligned divestment trends" are creating new pressures on traditional manufacturers, which may drive them toward less-regulated markets.

Role of Non-State Actors (NSAs)

Non-state actors (NSAs) play a dual role as both the primary users of illicit arms and as intermediaries in the trafficking process.

Private Military and Security Companies (PMCs)

The emergence of private companies contracted to provide military services has contributed to SALW proliferation. These actors provide "dual services," ranging from logistical support to direct on-the-ground combat. PMCs often serve as "arms brokers" and transportation agents, facilitating the procurement of weaponry for their clients. The lack of a comprehensive international framework to control PMCs leaving most to "self-regulation" remains a major concern for the proliferation of military-grade weapons to non-state actors.

Terrorists and Organized Criminals

Terrorist organisations like Boko Haram in Sudan are now sophisticated "end-users" with their own decentralized supply chains. They utilize SALW not only for kinetic operations but to "consolidate control" over volatile areas through racketeering and extortion. The "crime-terror nexus" ensures that weapons flow along historic trade routes, where they are used as a form of "currency" to secure informal loans or as trading commodities.

Arms Manufacturers and Regional Organizations

Arms companies are under increasing pressure to implement "stricter end-use monitoring," yet the "culture of profiteering" often drives the supply of weapons to high-risk zones. Meanwhile, regional organizations like the African Union and the League of Arab States (LAS) are attempting to "harmonize stockpile management" and support amnesty programs. Initiatives like the "EU-LAS project" aim to build national capacities to combat illicit trade, but progress remains contingent on the political will of individual Member States.

Important Resolutions

The DISEC process is guided by several landmark resolutions that establish the mandate for small arms control and the monitoring of sanctions regimes.

- **UNGA Resolution 72/57 (2017):** Established the groundwork for the modern global process on the illicit trade in small arms and light weapons.
- **UNSC Resolution 2117 (2013):** The first Security Council resolution focused specifically on the illicit transfer and destabilizing accumulation of SALW.
- **UNSC Resolution 2616 (2021):** Addressing the illicit transfer and diversion of arms in violation of Council-mandated embargoes, linking the lifting of embargoes to stockpile management capacity.
- **UNSC Resolution 2791 (2025):** Extending the mandate of the Panel of Experts on Sudan until October 2026 to monitor the Darfur arms embargo.
- **UNSC Resolution 2801 (2025):** Renewing the Yemen sanctions regime and requesting reports on the flow of dual-use precursor chemicals.
- **UNSC Resolution 2812 (2026):** Extending monthly reporting on Houthi attacks in the Red Sea, reflecting the threat posed by light weapons and drones to maritime security.

Conclusion

The year 2026 marks a critical juncture for the international community in its effort to eradicate the illicit trade in small arms and light weapons. The convergence of record-high levels of violence, the fracturing of the rules-based order, and the rise of transformative technologies like 3D printing and AI-assisted drones has created a "perfect storm" for proliferation. While

the UN Programme of Action and the Arms Trade Treaty remain the primary mechanisms for cooperation, their effectiveness is compromised by declining transparency and the tension between national sovereignty and international inspections.

To address these challenges, DISEC must move beyond traditional security responses and embrace holistic approaches that integrate small arms control into broader peacebuilding and development strategies. The 2026 Open-ended Technical Expert Group offers a unique opportunity to modernize international tracing standards for the digital age. Failure to act decisively will allow the illicit arms trade to continue as the primary driver of global conflict, undermining the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals and leaving millions of civilians vulnerable to weapon-enabled violence.

Questions a Resolution must Answer (QARMA)

1. How can the International Tracing Instrument (ITI) be updated in 2026 to effectively incorporate "ghost guns," 3D-printed parts, and modular weapon designs?
2. What objective criteria should the Security Council use to determine if a state has the "capacity to prevent diversion" before an arms embargo is lifted?
3. What measures can states take to regulate the "digital brokering" of arms on the Dark Web and track the use of cryptocurrencies in financing illicit SALW flows?
4. Should DISEC recommend the creation of a new, legally binding international regulatory framework to oversee the role of Private Military Companies in the conventional arms trade?
5. How can international sanctions be modified to disrupt the "indirect financing" of terrorist organizations that use SALW for extortion and the taxation of smuggling routes?
6. How can the UN balance the requirement for intrusive, on-site inspections of state stockpiles with the sovereign immunity and national security interests of Member States?
7. What specific mechanisms should be included in national action plans to address the acute impact of SALW on sexual and gender-based violence (SGBV)?
8. What roles should DISEC and the Security Council play in creating international rules to guide the use of small FPV drones and AI-assisted weaponry in future conflicts?